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Where the sea keeps scores too

Our correspondent's dispatch from Galle: a coastal town where history, weather and cricket move at their own pace, and where a young Indian side found itself **well ahead** of the tide.

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It is an August day, and the flight to Colombo is mostly full of passengers heading for a break in the Emerald Isle. Additionally, there are a few business travellers with family ties split between India and Sri Lanka, and a handful of cricket writers. The two-Test series across the Palk Strait beckons, and as the plane lands in the Sri Lankan capital, it is time to embrace the warmth of the neighbour, both from its people and the tropical weather.

The drive to Galle on the southern coast, on a silken highway, is a two-hour cruise past green swathes of trees, colourful kites fluttering in

the skies, and red-tile roof homes with tiny gardens. The road is of the highest quality, and when you see names like Matara with the distance mentioned, the thought of Sanath Jayasuriya, who hails from that town, naturally pops up.

Soon it is time to leave the highway and enter Galle. The road trip is quick and efficient, but other scribes mention their train journey as the better option, since the Indian Ocean is a steady companion.

Air of eternity

The Galle International Stadium is a sight for sore eyes. With the Indian Ocean a stone's throw away and the rugged Dutch fort placed like a sentinel next door, there is an air of eternity to the surroundings. This is a town that has evolved through history and, under colonial masters,

gained a multicultural vibe.

The coastal outpost has its ocean-spray frills, fresh fish, shops selling meals wrapped in steamed banana leaves, and hole-in-the-wall mechanic units servicing Bajaj autos. Most of the two-wheelers are imported from India, and everyone wears a helmet. Sri Lanka is a blend of alluring beauty and quiet efficiency.

Memories of the civil war may linger, but people have slowly moved on, getting over their scars and forging a new path, and every

Picturesque venue: At the Galle International Stadium, cricket unfolds against a backdrop where history, sea and sport meet in a single frame, making it one of the most evocative grounds in world cricket. AFP

